

The Problem Sounds in English Encountered by Non-Native Speakers of the Eastern Region of India

India being a Multi-Lingual country, is house to a wide range of languages and its associated dialects. Moving through the varied and diverse geographical regions and communities we find tremendous varieties of regional languages or dialects that preconditions the tongue, to mean colloquially, before learning a second or a third language. Officially, there are twenty-two languages (22) recognised by the Constitution of India as National Languages. Hindi is the Official Language of India and English, the Associate Official Language of India. Yet, we see an inclination towards English even though Hindi is the Official National Language of India. As far as English is concerned, even if people don't know they try to imitate the known words to them in an effort to speak English. Over the years English has assumed a position of importance as the language of the learned and a certain prestige value has been associated with it. The result manifests in everybody trying to speak English up to the level they can. This again results in an interesting observation: the sounds of English undergo various substitutions depending upon the nature of the language spoken by the native speaker as the mother tongue. This, in other words is known as the mother – tongue – influence or MTI.

Certain sounds of English are not produced the way they should be, because the native speaker's vocal apparatus has not produced it before. Such sounds pose a problem for the native speaker and are thus categorised as *problem sounds*. While certain sounds are problematic universally in the Indian context, others surface region-wise. Even educated Indians of different regions are found producing the problem sounds in a faulty way and most of the time being unaware of the sound they have produced. So, the present education system cannot guarantee flair in English speaking. In this paper, the effort will be to study these *problem sounds* region-wise and understand the causes, effects and propose remedies for the same.

The different languages of India belong to various language families such as Indo-European represented in its Indo-Iranian branch, Dravidian, Indo-Aryan, etc. The languages of India are written in Brahmi-derived scripts like Devanagari, Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Odia, Eastern Nagari- Assamese/Bengali, etc.

The People's Linguistic Survey of India (PLSI) did the first linguistic survey throughout the country for long twenty-one years (21) in which the survey was completed in four years and the preparatory work was done for long seventeen years (17). It was found that there are seven hundred and eighty different languages in India (780) which are spoken and about two hundred and fifty languages (250) are lost in the last fifty years (50).

Though there are different languages and scripts all have got different approach to English when it comes to speaking. English may seem easy to all but the ways in which it is expressed is very different as people speak. Here the geography plays a very important role in shaping the accent of the people and so there is a difference when people speak English from different geographical backgrounds.

As mentioned in the topic "The Problem Sounds in English" we will look at certain geographical area, i.e., the Eastern region of India and find out how mother tongue affects the pronunciation of the native dwellers. We will take into consideration the States of Odisha, West Bengal, Bihar and Jharkhand.

The analysis of the topic will be done through certain examples of words that the natives speak of these different states. And the differences will be pointed out through words transcription wherever possible to show how mother tongue affects the pronunciation in English.

The first region for consideration will be Odisha. Odisha is a state with 41,947,358 population according to 2011 census with 73.45% Literacy and the official languages are Odia and English. Although it has a fairly decent degree of literacy we see how certain vowels and consonants are faultily pronounced.

The consonants which pose a problem are: / f / , / v / , / ʃ / , / ʒ / , / θ / , and / ð /

While English / f / & / v / are friction consonants, the Odia native speaker produces it as plosives. Similarly, wherever / ʃ / should be produced, it is substituted by / s /. And, / θ / and / ð / are produced throughout India as stop consonants rather than friction consonants.

Further, people from Odisha have difficulties in producing some vowel sounds of English. For example, let's say bag and shake. Through the transcription will see how the vowel 'a' in 'bag' and the cluster consonant 'sh' in 'shake' changes when pronounced by the native dwellers. The problem sounds are /ae/, /ʌ/

- * Bag - /beg/
- * Shake - /seIk/

So, here we find how /a/ and /sh/ undergoes a change to /e/ and /eI/ respectively. The words Bag and Shake the different accent that the natives speak.

Similarly, in West Bengal we also find certain changes in their accent when it comes to English pronunciation. West Bengal is a state with 91,347,736 population according to 2011 census and the Literacy count is 77.08% with Bengali, English and Nepali as its Official Languages. In all languages in India there are consonant faults and vowel faults. Here we see how the stress in the letters is found in the words they speak. Words like Bus, Truck will give a clear idea how the natives speak. The problem sound is /ʌ/

- * Bus - /ba:s/
- * Truck - /tra:k/

We see here how there is a long stress on the vowels in the words Bus and Truck which shows the pronunciation in a different way where /ʌ/ is replaced by /a:/ .

Now moving to the states of Bihar and Jharkhand together we will see how Hindi influences the language of English when the native dwellers converse. The statistics of both the states are 103,804,637 and 32,988,134 population according to 2011 census. The Literacy percentage in Bihar is 63.82% (28th), 73.4% (male) and 53.3% (female) and in Jharkhand is 67.6% (25th) with Official Languages as Hindi and Urdu in Bihar and Hindi, Urdu, Santali, Bengali, Odia in Jharkhand, respectively. Here in Bihar and Jharkhand the problem sounds are /z/, /s/. For instance, Rose and School

- * Rose - /rod₃/
- * School- /Iskul/

From the above transcription we see how the actual pronunciation is changed and /z/ is replaced with /d₃/ and /s/ is replaced with /l/.

The problem sounds found in the Eastern States of India where Odisha, West Bengal, Bihar and Jharkhand were taken into consideration is now quite evident. The transcriptions done in the above instances clearly shows how mother tongue affects pronunciation in English. Not only these States undergo change in pronunciation but all the States all over the country is challenged with the same issue. The dialects and the language that a region adopts becomes the basis for the natives to speak for which when the native dweller speaks in English there is a difference.

The accent found in South India won't be same as that in North India or the Western Part of India matching to the Eastern Part of India. It is all because of geography and the language that the people adopted from the different language families like Indo-Aryan, Dravidian, Indo-Iranian, etc.

So the question 'Do all Indian speak proper English without problem sounds even if they are educated?' is something to be thought of. It is not only constraint to those States as mentioned we may even find different pronunciation in different States such as Andhra Pradesh, Jammu & Kashmir, Punjab, etc. Like native residents of Andhra Pradesh cannot speak /æ/ where the consonant starts with /æ/ like the letter H. Similarly in Jammu & Kashmir people will misspell School like /s ə kul/ instead of /sku:l/

Therefore, these are the problems I wanted to put forth which is not known to many of us.